

Carthamus tinctorius (Asteraceae) Safflower, Hong Hua (Chinese)

Description Annual herb growing to 3 ft (90 cm). Has long spiny leaves with 6 oblong-oval leaflets, and groups of yellow flowers arising from the leaf axils.

Habitat & Cultivation Thought to be native to Iran and northwestern India, this herb is also found in North America and the Far East. It grows in open areas and is gathered in summer.

Parts Used Flowers, seeds, seed oil.

Constituents Safflower contains lignans, polysaccharides and a volatile oil. The seeds contain a fixed oil, up to 80% linoleic acid.

History & Folklore In 19th century North American herbal medicine, safflower was used to induce sweating, to promote the onset of a menstrual period and as a treatment for measles. Safflower flowers are falsely sold as saffron (*Crocus sativus*, p. 89).

Medicinal Actions & Uses In Chinese herbal medicine, the flowers are given to stimulate menstruation and to relieve abdominal pain. The flowers are also used to cleanse and heal wounds and sores and to treat measles. In the Anglo-American herbal tradition, the flowers are given as a treatment for fever and skin rashes. The unpurified seed oil is purgative.

Research Chinese research indicates that safflower flowers can reduce coronary artery disease, and lower cholesterol levels. Safflower contains a polysaccharide that has been shown to stimulate immune function in mice. Safflower oil also lowers cholesterol levels.

Caution Do not take the flowers or seeds during pregnancy (seed oil is safe).

Carum carvi (Apiaceae) Caraway

Description Aromatic annual growing to 2 ft (60 cm). Has ridged stem, feathery leaves, and umbels of white flowers in midsummer. Exploding capsules each contain 2 small narrow seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Caraway grows wild in Europe, North Africa, and Asia. It prefers sunny sites up to 6,600 ft (2,000 m) above sea level. It is cultivated in Europe, Russia, North Africa, and the US, and the seeds are harvested ripe in late summer.

Parts Used Seeds, essential oil.

Constituents Caraway contains a volatile oil high in carvone (about 50%) and limonene. It also contains a fixed oil, flavonoids, polysaccharides, proteins, and furanocoumarins.

History & Folklore Caraway seed is "conductive to all the cold griefs of the head and stomach... and has a moderate quality whereby it breaketh wind, and provoketh urine" (Nicholas Culpeper, *The English Physitian*, 1652). The seeds are commonly used in cooking.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Caraway is similar in action to anise (*Pimpinella anisum*, p. 248) and fennel (*Foeniculum vulgare*, p. 212). Being antispasmodic, the seeds soothe the digestive tract, acting directly on the intestinal muscles to relieve colic and cramps as well as bloating and flatulence. They sweeten the breath, improve appetite, counter heart irregularity caused by excess digestive gas, and ease cramping period pain. In addition, the seeds are expectorant and tonic and are frequently used in bronchitis and cough remedies, especially those for children. Caraway has a reputation for increasing breast-milk production. The diluted essential oil is useful for scabies.

Research In a German clinical trial (1999), patients with dyspepsia were given a combination of peppermint and caraway essential oils. Overall, patients experienced a significant reduction in symptoms.

Caution Do not use the essential oil internally except under professional supervision.



Castanea sativa (Fagaceae) Sweet Chestnut

Description Deciduous tree growing to a height of 100 ft (30 m). Has smooth silver-grey bark, lance-shaped dark green leaves, male and female catkins, and spiny yellow-green seed cases containing 2–3 glossy brown nuts.



Sweet chestnut nuts are a nutritious food and the leaves are useful for treating coughs.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Mediterranean, Asia Minor, and the Caucasus, sweet chestnut grows freely across Europe, including Britain. It is cultivated for its timber and for its nuts, which are collected in the autumn.

Parts Used Leaves, bark.

Constituents Sweet chestnut contains tannins, plastoquinones, and mucilage.

History & Folklore Tradition has it that the sweet chestnut tree was carried from Turkey to Sardinia and from there it subsequently spread through Europe, arriving in Britain with the Romans. The nuts are a nutritious foodstuff that can be roasted, candied, or made into a flour. The flowers are sometimes added to blends of aromatic tobaccos.

Medicinal Actions & Uses An infusion of sweet chestnut leaves is taken to treat whooping cough, bronchitis and bronchial congestion. The preparation tightens the mucous membranes and inhibits racking coughs. A decoction of leaves or bark is also valuable as a gargle for sore throats, and may be taken for diarrhea. The leaves are used in the treatment of rheumatic conditions, to ease lower back pain and also to relieve stiff joints or muscles.

Related Species The Mohicans in North America used an infusion obtained from American chestnut leaves (*C. dentata*) to treat whooping cough. In his *Natural History of North Carolina* (1737), John Brickell reports that the "leaves or bark of the tree boiled in wine are good against the bloody flux [excessive bleeding]."